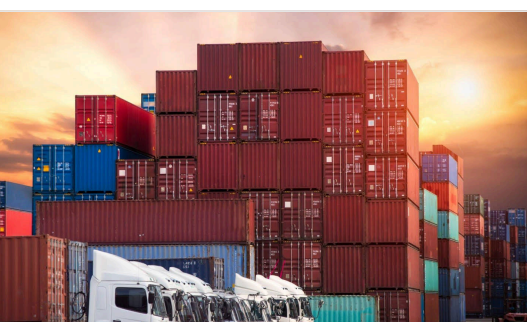




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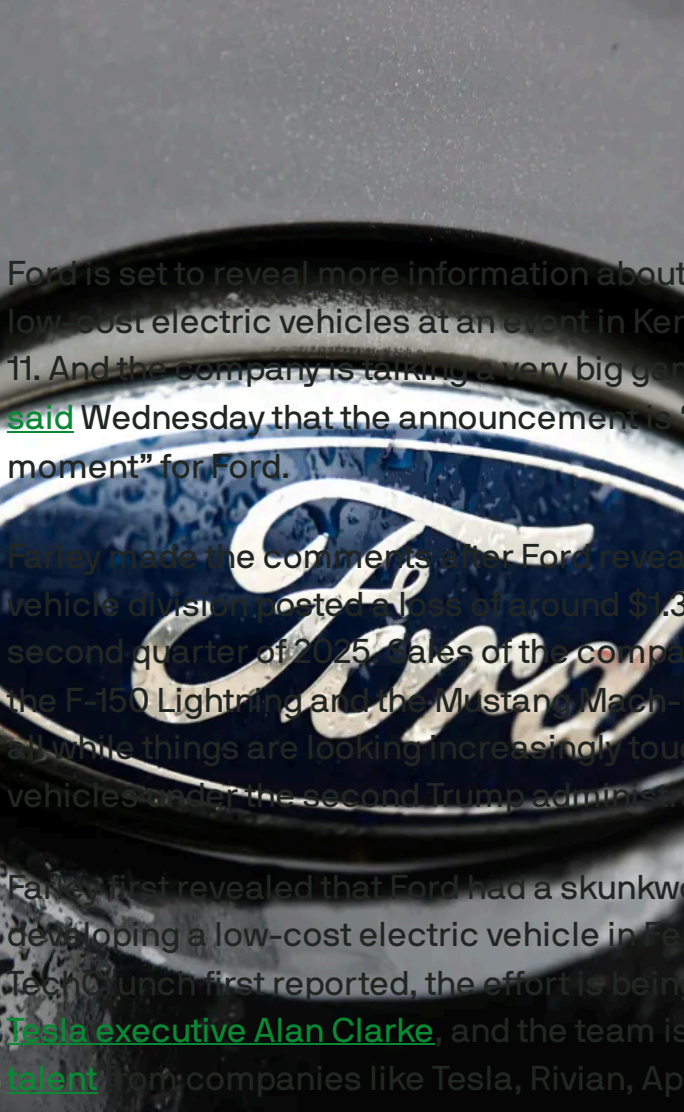
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Ford to reveal more about
its new low-cost electric
vehicles on August 11



Ford is set to reveal more information about its upcoming low-cost electric vehicles at an event in Kentucky on August 11. And the company is talking a very big game: CEO Jim Farley [said](#) Wednesday that the announcement is “a Model T moment” for Ford.

Farley made the comments after Ford revealed its electric vehicle division posted a loss of around \$1.3 billion in the second quarter of 2025. Sales of the company’s top two EVs, the F-150 Lightning and the Mustang Mach-E, are declining, all while things are looking increasingly tough for electric vehicles under the second Trump administration.

Farley first revealed that Ford had a skunkworks team developing a low-cost electric vehicle in February 2024. As [TechCrunch](#) first reported, the effort is being led by [former Tesla executive Alan Clarke](#), and the team is [brimming with talent](#) from companies like Tesla, Rivian, Apple, and Lucid Motors.

IMAGE CREDITS: JAKUB PORZYCKI / GETTY IMAGES

The company has been deliberately vague about any specifics, but has admitted that the first vehicle to be built on this new low-cost platform [will be a mid-size pickup truck](#) set for release in 2027. Ford has said it will build “multiple vehicle styles — for both retail and commercial customers” on the platform, and that these vehicles will feature “personalized digital experiences.”

Cheaper models could help Ford, but 2027 is still a long way out.

While there are basically no mass-market electric vehicles available in the U.S. at or under \$30,000, that likely won’t be the case when Ford’s secretive EVs hit the market in two years. Tesla has said it will start selling a stripped-down (and possibly smaller) Model Y SUV later this year. General Motors is [bringing back the Chevy Bolt next year](#). And Jeff Bezos-backed startup Slate Auto is putting its own [low-cost electric pickup on sale as early as late 2026](#).

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Federal regulators give Zoox an exemption for its custom-built robotaxis

Kirsten Korosec — 12:02 PM PDT · August 6, 2025

Zoox an exemption to demonstrate its custom-built robotaxis on public roads and closed a related investigation into whether the Amazon-owned company had sidestepped federal regulations.

The decision, which was announced Wednesday, clears up a long-standing debate over whether Zoox’s custom-built autonomous vehicles complied with federal motor vehicle safety standards, which place requirements on vehicles such as having a steering wheel and pedals. Zoox had argued that it did and announced in July 2022 that it had self-certified; NHTSA balked. The agency opened an investigation in March 2023 to look into the matter, and specifically the process and data that Zoox had used to self-certify.

The investigation didn’t slow Zoox’s development and testing of its autonomous vehicle technology. In early 2023, Zoox began [testing its custom-built robotaxis](#), which don’t have a steering wheel or other traditional controls, on public roads near its Foster City, California headquarters. The company has since expanded its testing footprint to [Las Vegas and San Francisco](#).

Zoox does not operate a commercial service yet. However, in San Francisco it has opened its robotaxis up to employees and hosted family and friends. Earlier this year, the company launched an Zoox Explorer program, aimed at early public riders, in Las Vegas.

For now, the exemption allows Zoox to demonstrate the robotaxis, not operate them commercially.

NHTSA’s announcement is connected to its [new national framework](#), which the agency argues will make it easier for companies to deploy autonomous vehicles without traditional manual driving controls — like steering wheels, pedals, and sideview mirrors — at scale.

The framework allows NHTSA to green-light the sale and commercialization of autonomous vehicles that are not compliant with federal safety standards due to a lack of manual controls.



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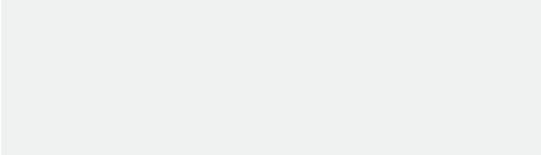
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The revised process involves an expedited application that allows companies like Zoox to receive exemptions for testing and demonstrations, and eventually, commercial operations. Zoox spokesperson Whitney Jencks said in an email that Zoox is working in close cooperation with NHTSA on this process, beginning with the demonstration exemption and followed by the commercial exemption.

As part of the agreement, NHTSA has closed its investigation into Zoox's self-certification of its AVs. Zoox has agreed to remove or cover all statements that its purpose-built vehicles comply with applicable Federal Motor Vehicle Safety Standards.

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Tesla shuts down Dojo, the AI training supercomputer that Musk said would be key to full self-driving

Rebecca Bellan — 3:19 PM PDT · August 7, 2025

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN/TECHCRUNCH

Tesla is breaking up the team behind its [Dojo supercomputer](#), ending the automaker's play at developing in-house chips for driverless technology, according to [Bloomberg](#).

Dojo's lead, Peter Bannon, is leaving the company, and the remaining team members will be reassigned to other data center and compute projects within Tesla, per Bloomberg's reporting, which cited anonymous sources.

The disbanding of Tesla's Dojo efforts follows the departure of around 20 workers, who left the automaker to start their own [AI company called DensityAI](#). The new startup is reportedly coming out of stealth soon and is building chips, hardware, and software that will power data centers for AI that are used in robotics, by AI agents, and in automotive applications. DensityAI was founded by former Dojo head [Ganesh Venkataramanan](#) and ex-Tesla employees Bill Chang and Ben Floering.

It also comes at a crucial time for Tesla.

[CEO Elon Musk has pushed](#) to get shareholders to view Tesla as an AI and robotics company, despite a limited robotaxi launch in Austin this past June that featured Model Y vehicles with a human in the front passenger seat and resulted in a number of reported incidents of the vehicles exhibiting problematic driving behavior.

Tesla's decision to shut down Dojo, which Musk has been talking about since 2019, is a major shift in strategy. Musk has said that Dojo would be the cornerstone of Tesla's AI ambitions and its goal to reach full self-driving due to its ability to "process truly vast amounts of video data." He talked about Dojo, albeit briefly, as recently as the company's second-quarter earnings call.

In 2023, Morgan Stanley predicted Dojo could add \$500 billion to the company's market value by unlocking new revenue streams in the form of robotaxis and software services. Just last year, Musk noted that Tesla's AI team would "[double down](#)" on Dojo in the lead-up to [Tesla's robotaxi reveal](#), which happened in October.

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Jeh Aerospace nets \$11M to scale the commercial aircraft supply chain in India

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But talk about Dojo halted around August 2024, when Musk began touting Cortex instead, Tesla's "giant new AI training supercluster being built at Tesla HQ in Austin to solve real-world AI."

The Dojo project was one part supercomputer, one part in-house chip-making. Tesla unveiled its D1 chip when it formally announced Dojo at its first AI Day in 2021. [Venkataramanan](#) presented the chip, which Tesla said would be used alongside Nvidia's GPU to power the Dojo supercomputer. The automaker also said it was working on a next-gen D2 chip that would solve any information flow bottlenecks of its predecessor.

Sources told Bloomberg that now Tesla plans to increase its reliance on Nvidia, as well as other external tech partners like AMD for compute and Samsung for chip manufacturing. Tesla last month signed a [\\$16.5 billion deal with Samsung](#) to make its AI6 inference chips, a chip design that promises to scale from powering FSD and Tesla's Optimus humanoid robots all the way to high-performance AI training in data centers.

During Tesla's second-quarter earnings call, Musk hinted at potential redundancies.

“Thinking about Dojo 3 and the AI6 inference chip, it seems like intuitively, we want to try to find convergence there, where it’s basically the same chip,” Musk said.

The news comes as [Tesla’s board offers Musk a \\$29 billion pay package](#) to keep him at Tesla and help push the company’s AI efforts forward, rather than getting too sidetracked by his other companies, including the more pure-play AI startup xAI.

TechCrunch has reached out to Tesla for more information.

Have a sensitive tip or confidential documents? We’re reporting on the inner workings of the AI industry — from the companies shaping its future to the people impacted by their decisions. Reach out to Rebecca Bellan at rebecca.bellan@techcrunch.com and Maxwell Zeff at maxwell.zeff@techcrunch.com. For secure communication, you can contact us via Signal at [@rebeccabellan.491](https://www.signal.me) and [@mzeff.88](https://www.signal.me).

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IMAGE CREDITS: JEH AEROSPACE

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Jeh Aerospace nets \$11M to scale the commercial aircraft supply chain in India

Jagmeet Singh — 5:30 PM PDT · August 4, 2025

Indian startup Jeh Aerospace founders Vishal Sanghavi and Venkatesh Mudragalla have had a front-row seat to the commercial aircraft sector and its growing production bottleneck.

The two former Tata Group executives spent close to two decades in different positions at the company and worked on projects that included participation from global aerospace companies, including Boeing, Sikorsky, and Lockheed Martin.

Now, armed with \$11 million in Series A funding, the pair are working to ease global supply chain bottlenecks by scaling the production of metallic components for aero engines and aerostructures, which it then sells to U.S.-based Tier 1

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suppliers that work with commercial aircraft manufacturers such as Airbus and Boeing.

And they plan to help India become a destination for aerospace component manufacturing in the process.

“At Tatas, we unlocked India’s potential for these large OEMs, Boeing, Airbus, Sikorsky, and GE [General Electric], but we wanted Jeh Aerospace to unlock India’s potential for the large Tier 1 and Tier 2 manufacturers in the supply chain,” said Sanghavi, who is also CEO at Jeh.



JEH AEROSPACE CO-FOUNDERS VENKATESH MUDRAGALLA (LEFT) AND VISHAL SANGHAVI (RIGHT).

IMAGE CREDITS: JEH AEROSPACE

[Jeh Aerospace](#), which is headquartered in Atlanta to better access its U.S. customer base, has a 60,000-square-foot software-based, precision manufacturing facility in the southern Indian city of Hyderabad. The 3-year-old startup has combined precision machinery, robotics, and IoT devices to slash product introduction lead times from the industry’s traditional 15-week timeline to 15 days.

Jeh Aerospace’s software-defined manufacturing approach helps bring predictability and dynamic scheduling to allow offering a consistent supply to customers with no compromises on quality, Sanghavi said.

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And it seems VCs and strategic investors are interested in Jeh Aerospace's pitch.

The Series A round was led by Elevation Capital, with participation from General Catalyst. With the infusion of the new capital, Jeh Aerospace has raised about \$15 million in total from institutional venture capital firms. The VC fresh funding comes less than a month after the startup received an undisclosed strategic investment from IndiGo Ventures, a corporate venture capital arm of Indian carrier IndiGo.

Ashray Iyengar, principal at Elevation Capital, said the company "built a truly differentiated approach to aerospace manufacturing."

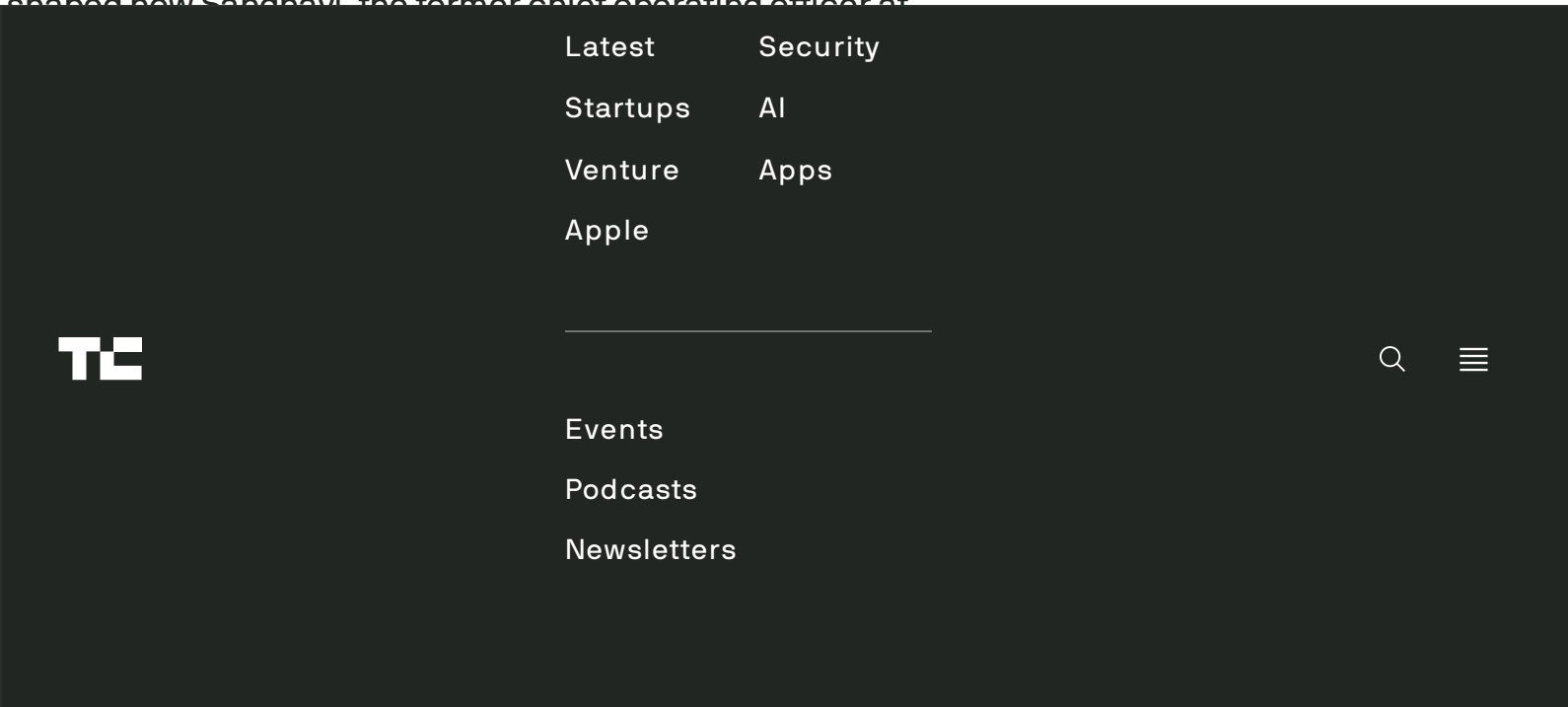
Aircraft production bottleneck

Global air traffic demand rose 10.4% year-over-year in 2024, surpassing 2019 levels by 3.8%, per the International Air Transport Association data [released](#) earlier this year.

The rebound has spurred airlines to expand fleets, pushing up orders even as the industry grapples with talent and

production bottlenecks, as Deloitte [notes](#) in a recent report. Tier 1 suppliers are facing extended lead times as the [commercial aircraft backlog reaches a record of nearly 15,700 units](#), according to McKinsey.

Jeh Aerospace’s founders believe using technology to scale production of metallic components for aero engines and aerostructures will unplug that bottleneck. That premise has shaped how Sanghavi, the former chief operating officer at



*Includes narrow-body and wide-body aircraft.

IMAGE CREDITS:MCKINSEY AEROSPACE & DEFENSE PRACTICE

Instead of working directly with OEMs like Airbus and Boeing, which make 30% of commercial aircraft, Jeh Aerospace deliberately decided to tap Tier 1 and Tier 2 manufacturers, Sanghavi told TechCrunch, adding this group makes 60% to 70% of aircraft.

The startup currently has half a dozen paying customers, including Vermont-based GS Precision and Ohio-headquartered RH Aero. Sanghavi said each of these customers is a “high dollar, high ARR customer,” and they have the potential to become large accounts in the next one to two years.

“What we believe is that to work with lesser, but better customers, not to have a transactional relationship, but a far deeper and meaningful relationship. So, we are also very, very focused on not having too many customers,” he said. “The business doesn’t need too many customers because you can really scale with few customers very fast and very quickly.”

The company has also assembled an advisory team with deep ties to commercial aircraft OEMs. The startup counts former Boeing India president Pratyush (Prat) Kumar and former Airbus India CEO and managing director Dwaraka Srinivasan among its early advisers and backers.

Jeh Aerospace has made notable manufacturing and financial progress in its short life.

Since its \$2.75 million seed round in January last year, Jeh Aerospace says it has delivered more than 100,000 flight-critical components and tools on time. The startup has also established a machine capacity exceeding 250,000 hours annually.

In the last financial year, the startup reached \$6 million in annualized recurring revenue (ARR) and achieved profitability after taxes. Sanghavi told TechCrunch that it projects a 3x to 4x increase in its ARR this year and also boasts an order book worth \$100 million.



JEH AEROSPACE'S FACILITY INCLUDES A CENTER OF AEROSPACE SKILL FOR TALENT TRAINING.

IMAGE CREDITS: JEH AEROSPACE

The company plans to use the new \$11 million in capital to scale its manufacturing and inspection capabilities by investing in next-generation digital production technologies, Sanghavi said.

The Jeh Aerospace co-founders see an opportunity to bring more local manufacturing to India and strengthen the country's position on the global aerospace map, much like its recent [emergence as a hub for iPhone production](#).

India already plays a growing role in aerospace manufacturing, with Airbus [sourcing \\$1.4 billion](#) worth of components annually from the country and targeting \$2 billion by 2030. Boeing, for its part, is [aiming for a \\$1.3 billion annual spend](#) and announced its plans to [invest \\$200 million](#) in a new engineering and technology center in Bengaluru in 2023. Still, the South Asian nation has yet to achieve large-scale success in aerospace component manufacturing — a gap companies like Jeh Aerospace are hoping to fill.

Although few Indian startups operate in aerospace component manufacturing, the sector includes players like JJG Aero, which appears to be a peer to Jeh Aerospace based on industry positioning. Sanghavi declined to comment specifically on JJG and noted that his startup sees its primary competition among U.S.-based tier-2 suppliers.

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Foxconn sells former GM factory to mystery buyer after failing to make EVs

Sean O'Kane — 11:43 AM PDT · August 4, 2025

Foxconn has sold the former GM factory it has owned for three years after failing to stand up any meaningful, large-scale electric vehicle production there.

The pivot marks the second major failure of Foxconn to deliver on its promises to help revive U.S. manufacturing. The iPhone-maker once promised to build a giant LCD factory in Wisconsin — a project that Donald Trump called the “[eighth wonder of the world](#)” during his first term — and wound up underdelivering to [an extreme degree](#).

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Foxconn says the buyer is an “existing business partner” named “Crescent Dune LLC,” an entity that was created in Delaware just 12 days ago, according to records filed with the state. Matt Dewine, a spokesperson for Foxconn, declined to say more about the buyer.

Foxconn sold the factory and land for around \$88 million and machinery and equipment from its EV subsidiaries for around \$287 million, Taiwan stock exchange filings show.

A Foxconn representative told [Automotive News](#) the company will remain “involved in the manufacturing of products for customers at the Lordstown facility” and claimed it is “committed to customers and suppliers” in the automotive

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industry. But The Wall Street Journal [reported Monday](#) that Foxconn now plans to build AI servers at the factory. Dewine did not immediately respond to a request for comment on the report.

Foxconn announced the deal to buy the former GM plant in 2021 for \$230 million, when it was still owned by EV startup Lordstown Motors. At the time, Foxconn Chairman Young Liu said it was going to be the “most important electric vehicle manufacturing and R&D hub in North America.”

While Foxconn was developing EVs of its own in Asia, it was also focused on contract manufacturing in the United States. And, in short order, three of the electric vehicle companies Foxconn hoped would occupy the factory went bankrupt.

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Foxconn actually built a few EVs at the factory for the now-defunct Lordstown Motors. But the Taiwanese electronics

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giant wound up in a bitter fight with that troubled EV startup. Lordstown Motors filed for bankruptcy in June 2023, and accused Foxconn — which had become an investor in the startup — of “starving it of cash,” and said it “maliciously and in bad faith destroyed that business.”

Foxconn also took a flier on a small EV startup called IndiEV, claiming it would build its electric SUV at the Ohio factory. IndiEV filed for bankruptcy in [October 2023](#) with less than \$3 million in the bank. Foxconn was supposed to [build EVs for Fisker Inc.](#) as well. Fisker [filed for bankruptcy in June 2024](#).

A fourth company, Monarch Tractor, has [not had much of an impact](#), with Foxconn making no more than a few hundred electric tractors. Monarch’s CEO, Praveen Penmetsa, did not respond to an emailed request for comment about whether its tractors will continue to be built in Ohio.

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Sean O'Kane

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Sean O’Kane is a reporter who has spent a decade covering the rapidly-evolving business and technology of the transportation...

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